Billix

Billix printable · Bill check

The 15-Minute Bill Audit

Find out whether a bill changed because of your use, the price, the calendar or a mistake.



How to use it

1 Gather this bill, last month's bill and the same month's bill from last year.

2 Work through the eight steps in order, and write what you find on an audit sheet.

3 Split the change into days, price, use and fixed charges, then read your results.

What you need

- This bill
- Last month's bill
- Same month last year or the usage chart
- A calculator
- A pen

Four reasons a bill changes

Your use
Use per day, compared with the same month last year.

The price
Price per unit, each tier's rate and the fixed charges.

The calendar
Extra days in the billing period.

A mistake
A wrong reading, duplicate charges, services you do not recognize, missing credits.

WHY TWO COMPARISON BILLS

Compare use with last year. Last month's bill shows a new charge, a price change or a catch-up reading as soon as it starts.

MAKE IT A HABIT

Run the audit on every bill for three months. After that it goes faster, because you will know what normal looks like for your home.

Inside this printable

2 Minute by minute: the eight steps

3 Audit sheet, bill 1

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5 Worked example and reading your results

From The Billix Household Utility Savings Handbook

This audit is adapted from worksheet B2, taught in sections 1.3 to 1.8. The full handbook (246 pages, 26 worksheets) explains every bill line by line.

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2 The eight steps

A wrong reading, extra days, a new price or a new fixed charge can explain a change before you look for a cause in your home. Tags such as 1.7 are the handbook sections that teach each step.

1–2	3–4	5–6	7–8	9–10	11–12	13–14	15
Account	Reading	Per day	Price	Fixed	Split	Warnings	Messages

- [ ] **1–2 MINUTES** — **Confirm the account** 1.7
  Check the name, service address and account number. Check that the meter number matches the number on your meter. Read meters from the outside only: never open a cover or break a seal.

- [ ] **3–4 MINUTES** — **Check the reading** 1.5
  Is it actual or estimated? Write down the current and previous readings. If last month's reading was estimated and this one is actual, part of this bill may be a catch-up.

- [ ] **5–6 MINUTES** — **Put it on a per-day basis** 1.4
  Count the days. Divide the use by the days, and the total due by the days. Do the same for last year's bill.

- [ ] **7–8 MINUTES** — **Find the price** 1.8, Rule 2
  Add up the usage charges and divide by the units used. Compare with last year. On a tiered bill, compare each tier's rate too. If none changed, a higher average price comes from more of your use falling in a higher tier, not from a price rise.

- [ ] **9–10 MINUTES** — **Total the fixed charges** 1.3
  Add up every charge that is not per unit. Did any rise since last year, or appear for the first time since last month?

- [ ] **11–12 MINUTES** — **Split the change**
  Put a dollar figure on the days, the price, the fixed charges and your use, with the worksheet on your audit sheet.

- [ ] **13–14 MINUTES** — **Look for warning signs** 1.7
  Late fees, a past-due balance, duplicate charges, services you do not recognize, missing credits.

- [ ] **15 MINUTE** — **Read the messages**
  Look for notices of rate changes, promotions ending or plan renewals.

SAFETY
Read meters from the outside only: never open a cover or break a seal.

3 Audit sheet: bill 1

Fill in the Last bill column for the reading type, the price, the fixed charges and any new lines. Compare use with the same month last year.

SERVICE | PROVIDER | BILLING PERIOD | DATE AUDITED

Check	This bill	Last bill	Same month last year	Notes
Meter number matches your meter				
Reading type (actual or estimated)				
Days in the period				
Use (kWh, therms, gallons or CCF)				
Use per day				
Total due				
Cost per day				
Price per unit Usage charges divided by use				
Fixed charges, total				
New or changed lines				
Late fees or past-due balance				
Messages about rates or plans				

Split the change

Use this bill and last year's. Leave taxes out. A part can be a minus number.

1 Days	The extra days	×	Last year's use per day	×	Last year's price	=	Days part, $
2 Price	Last year's use per day	×	This bill's days	×	The change in price per unit	=	Price part, $
3 Use	The change in use per day	×	This bill's days	×	This bill's price	=	Use part, $
4 Fixed	This bill's fixed charges	–	Last year's fixed charges			=	Fixed part, $

Total of parts 1 to 4, $ | Change in the amount due, $ | Difference, $

If the change in the amount due differs from the total by more than the taxes and a few cents of rounding, look for a credit, a late fee, a past balance or an error 1.7.

4 Audit sheet: bill 2

Fill in the Last bill column for the reading type, the price, the fixed charges and any new lines. Compare use with the same month last year.

SERVICE | PROVIDER | BILLING PERIOD | DATE AUDITED

Check	This bill	Last bill	Same month last year	Notes
Meter number matches your meter				
Reading type (actual or estimated)				
Days in the period				
Use (kWh, therms, gallons or CCF)				
Use per day				
Total due				
Cost per day				
Price per unit Usage charges divided by use				
Fixed charges, total				
New or changed lines				
Late fees or past-due balance				
Messages about rates or plans				

Split the change

Use this bill and last year's. Leave taxes out. A part can be a minus number.

1 Days	The extra days	×	Last year's use per day	×	Last year's price	=	Days part, $
2 Price	Last year's use per day	×	This bill's days	×	The change in price per unit	=	Price part, $
3 Use	The change in use per day	×	This bill's days	×	This bill's price	=	Use part, $
4 Fixed	This bill's fixed charges	–	Last year's fixed charges			=	Fixed part, $

Total of parts 1 to 4, $ | Change in the amount due, $ | Difference, $

If the change in the amount due differs from the total by more than the taxes and a few cents of rounding, look for a credit, a late fee, a past balance or an error 1.7.

5 Worked example and reading your results

Split the change: a worked check

ILLUSTRATIVE

Sam's bills, from section 1.6 of the handbook. The four parts add up to the change in charges before taxes. If the change in the amount due differs from them by more than the taxes and a few cents of rounding, look for a credit, a late fee, a past balance or an error [1.7].

1	Days	The extra days: 1	×	Last year's use per day: 15.0 kWh	×	Last year's price: $0.17	=	Days part, $: +$2.55
2	Price	Last year's use per day: 15.0 kWh	×	This bill's days: 31	×	The change in price per unit: $0.01	=	Price part, $: +$4.65
3	Use	The change in use per day: −1.0 kWh	×	This bill's days: 31	×	This bill's price: $0.18	=	Use part, $: −$5.58
4	Fixed	This bill's fixed charges: $12.00	−	Last year's fixed charges: $11.00			=	Fixed part, $: +$1.00

Total of parts 1 to 4, $: +$2.62

Together: +$2.62, the whole rise from $87.50 to $90.12. The use part matches the $5.58 that Sam's lower use saved.

Reading your results

Tick each row that applies.

	What you found	What it points to	Where to go next in the handbook
☐	**Use per day rose 5% or more**	Something in the home: weather, people, equipment or a leak	2.4 (electricity), 3.3 (gas), 5.3 (water) or 6.3 (sewer). For weather, 1.8, Rule 4
☐	**Price per unit rose**	A rate change, a rider or a plan or contract change	2.3 and 2.11 (electricity), 3.2 (gas) or 5.2 (water). For how rates change, 10.4
☐	**Only the number of days changed**	Nothing is wrong	No action needed
☐	**The reading was estimated**	A possible catch-up bill later	Section 1.5
☐	**A charge you cannot explain**	A possible error or unwanted service	10.2, then 10.3
☐	**A past-due balance or growing late fees**	A payment problem, not a price problem	10.9 and 12.5. With a shutoff notice, 12.8

MORE THAN ONE ROW?

Take them in the audit's order: reading, days, price, fixed charges, then use.

ABOUT THE 5% LINE

The 5% line for use per day is a Billix rule of thumb, not an official figure. A smaller change is worth noting and checking again on the next bill.